

China remained uneasy, and war flared up again in 1856. In this Second Opium War (also known as the Arrow War), the British were joined by the French. By 1860 China had been defeated, and was forced to grant further privileges to Britain, which were later extended to other Western powers.

### The Taiping Rebellion

China in the mid-19th century was not only under attack from foreign powers, it was also under threat from a series of internal rebellions, the largest of which was the Taiping Rebellion.

In 1836, a Christian teacher, Hong Xiuquan, had a series of dreams that led him to believe he had a mission to restore China to Christianity. He made converts among peasants and miners in Guangxi, south China, and in January 1851 declared the establishment of the *Taiping Tianguo*, the Heavenly Kingdom of Great Peace. In 1853, Taiping rebels

### The Chinese Army 1880

China's first modern army, the Anhui Army, which was raised by statesman Li Hongzhang to campaign against a series of mid-19th-century rebellions, adopted Western-style drills and Western-style weapons.



agreement that envoys of both sovereigns will sign the treaty, in English

signatures of the three Chinese ambassadors, Qiying, Yilibu, and Niu Jian

### The Nanjing Treaty

The Treaty of Nanjing, 1842, was the first of the "unequal treaties," which gave benefits to Western powers without offering reciprocal advantages to the Chinese state.

captured Nanjing, and established a state in which gambling and opium smoking were both banned, Taiping Christianity was the only religion, land was to be shared out equally, and women were given equal rights.

In 1860, a Taiping assault on Shanghai was defeated by the Western-trained "Ever-Victorious Army." In 1864, the Hunan army—organized on a network of personal loyalty and financed by a new tax on internal trade—recaptured Nanjing. Hong Xiuquan committed suicide and the rebellion came to an end, though pockets of Taiping resistance continued until 1868.

### Missionaries

Christian missionaries gained the right to preach, travel, and own property in China under the unequal treaties (see above). After 1860, the number of Protestant and Catholic missionaries operating in China rose sharply. Missionaries initially concentrated on converting the population, but later ran schools and hospitals. Their presence



agreement that envoys of both sovereigns will sign the treaty, in Chinese

signature of Henry Pottinger, the British ambassador to China

threatened the position of the Chinese scholar-officials, and anti-missionary incidents occurred, the most notorious being the massacre of French Sisters of Charity at Tianjin in 1870.

### Self-strengthening

After the Opium Wars, the scholar Wei Yuan suggested "building ships, making weapons, and learning the superior techniques of the barbarians." The first "self-strengthening" projects began in the 1860s. In 1866 Wojen, a Mongol Grand Secretary, complained that self-strengthening ideas were not compatible with traditional Confucian government. Nevertheless, in 1872 the statesman Li Hongzhang started a steamship company to compete with foreign shipping on the Yangzi, and later established coal mines that led to the building of China's first railroad.

However, Japan's dramatic defeat of China's army and navy in the Sino-Japanese War (see below) seemed to indicate that attempts at self-strengthening were a failure.

### DECISIVE MOMENT

#### SINO-JAPANESE WAR

The origins of this conflict lay in a struggle between China and Japan over influence in Korea. Despite expectations of a Chinese victory, the contest was one-sided. First the Huai army was defeated at Pyongyang in present-day North Korea. Then, in September 1894, the Chinese Beiyang fleet engaged the Japanese fleet off the mouth of the Yalu River, at the border of North Korea and China. Four Chinese ships were destroyed; the rest took refuge at Weihaiwei. China was forced to sign the Treaty of Shimonoseki, recognizing Korean independence, and ceding Taiwan to Japan.



### AFTER

In the wake of the Opium Wars, China experienced a period of unrest, both domestically and internationally.

#### SCRAMBLE FOR CHINA

China's defeat in the Sino-Japanese War precipitated a **scramble for territory**: Russia obtained an agreement to extend the Trans-Siberian railroad across Manchuria in northeast China; Germany seized Qingdao in the north; France obtained commercial concessions in the southwest; and Britain gained a 99-year lease on the "New Territories," opposite Hong Kong Island.

#### THE EMPRESS DOWAGER

In 1856, a concubine named **Yehonola** gave birth to the future Tongzhi emperor. As Empress Dowager Cixi **she dominated the court until 1908**. She has been accused of having murdered her daughter-in-law, of misappropriating naval funds, and of supporting the Boxer Uprising (see below).



EMPRESS DOWAGER CIXI

#### THE BOXER UPRISING

The Boxers United in Righteousness—so called because of the ritual "invincibility" boxing they practiced—attacked Beijing in May 1900 in a backlash **against Christian missionaries**. Britain sent 2,000 troops to stop them, but the Empress Dowager ordered the Imperial army to turn them away. Westerners were executed and thousands of **Chinese Christians were killed**. In the aftermath of the siege, Chinese officials were executed and compensation was paid to the West.